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Community Foundation™
for the Fox Valley Region

Marie Wels Coates Annual Scholarship Fund



Background:
Marie Violet Wels was born October 31, 1917, on a 200-acre farm in Dubuque County, Iowa. She completed grade school at the Cedar Ridge one room school, near her farm home. Marie graduated from eighth grade at the age of 12 and high school at age 16. Her family's only mode of transportation was a team of horses with a wagon. Each Monday morning, during high school, she walked 3 miles to a train depot and then reversed that commute home on Friday evenings after rooming in Dubuque during the week. Family lore tells stories of Marie hearing gun shots and bobcats growling in trees as she walked to and from the train depot.

Marie wanted to become a teacher, and with her parents' support, she continued her education at the University of Dubuque. She completed her university courses and began teaching, at age 17, grades 1-8, at Durango School, and then Derby Grange School, both one room schools. Since her farm home was miles from the Derby Grange School and having no transportation, she boarded at the home of a School Board member. She eventually bought a Model T Ford which allowed her to commute. In 1940 she married Merlin Coates, who she met as a child in Sunday school.

Marie and her husband farmed 80 acres and raised four children. She continued to teach part-time and completed her teaching certification through summer classes. When her husband passed away in 1976, she decided, at age 59, to reinvent herself and went back to school to study accounting. Over the years she worked in several accounting and bookkeeping positions, ending up with H&R Block as a seasonal tax preparer, retiring after 26 years at age of 86. After her husband's death, she sold the farm and traveled the world, looking to connect with ancestors and distant cousins. One of her trips was to the West Coast via train to attend the World's Fair. She also enjoyed bus travel in the USA, sometimes with grandchildren in tow.

Although born in 1917, Marie would now be considered a "feminist", supporting women's liberation. She believed women could do anything men could do and enjoyed being the first of her peers to do it, e.g., driving a farm tractor, buying and driving her own car, and much more! She encouraged strong independence in her three daughters and was a strong supporter of continuing education for women. Marie passed away on January 19, 2015, at the age of 97.

Eligibility: (taken into consideration to determine recipients)
- Students who are enrolled and are pursuing a bachelor's degree at Lakeland University in Plymouth, Wisconsin
- Students may enroll full-time (minimum 12 credits) or part-time (minimum of 6 credits)
- Minimum cumulative 2.0 GPA
- Preference will be given to students with an associate degree returning to college to attain their bachelor's degree
- Financial need will be considered

Award Amount:
One $1,250 non-renewable scholarship award for tuition expenses for the first semester of college. Students can re-apply each year they are eligible.

Selection:
Recipients are recommended each spring by the Lakeland University Scholarship Selection Committee.

Collecting the Award & Payment Procedure:
Recipients must fill out and submit Scholarship Acceptance Form and Scholarship Verification Form through the Scholarship Portal *(https://www.grantinterface.com/Home/Logon?urlkey=cffvrscholar)*. Recipients are required to provide supporting documents *as instructed* in the Scholarship Verification Form, such as class registration/list **with** credits listed, proof of major, grade transcript, etc.

After approval of online Scholarship Verification Form, the scholarship check will be paid directly to the school the recipient will be attending. The **Community Foundation communicates with students via email**; it is the student's responsibility to keep their Scholarship Portal account updated with their current email address.

Loss of Eligibility:
Failure to register at Lakeland University, pursuing a bachelor's degree as a part-time (minimum 6 credits) or full-time (minimum 12 credits) student.

Further Information:
- Lakeland University
- Community Foundation for the Fox Valley Region

Website: www.cffoxvalley.org/scholarship | Email scholarships@cffoxvalley.org | 920.702.7623